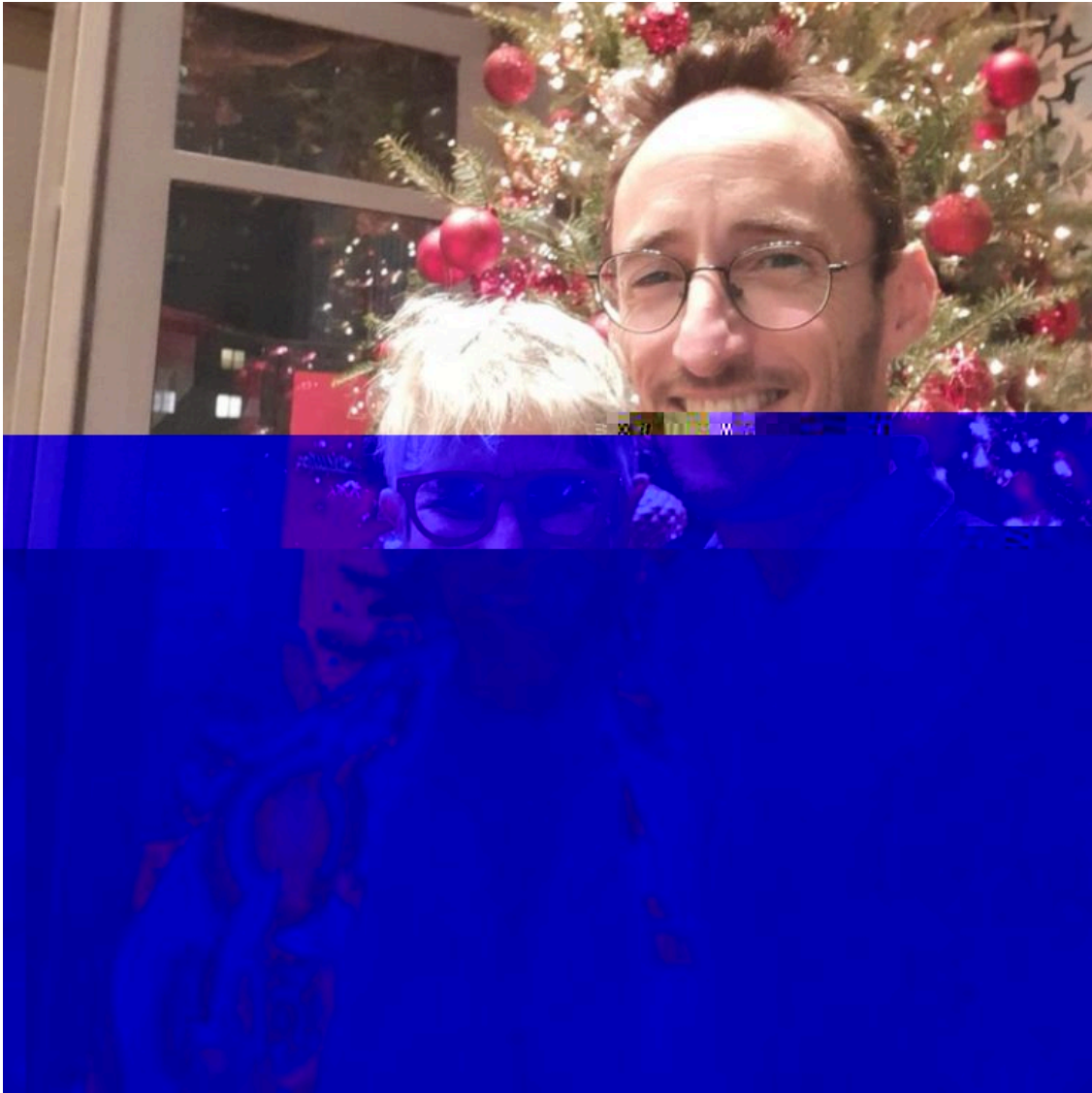


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JERUSALEM INTERNATIONAL FELLOWS

Dear <<First Name>>,

On the first night of Channukah, I met with Matan Israeli, head of [Muslala](#), the Host

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Matan is an extraordinary optimist. And a realist. Muslala is a "Garden of Eden" on the roof of (what I consider) one of the ugliest buildings in Israel, near the Mahane Yehuda market. Their rooftop boasts gardens and an apiary and gathering spaces for everyone in Jerusalem.

Some years ago Matan began a partnership with another incredible optimist/pragmatist, Palestinian urban planner and architect Tareq Nasser. They created **The Sinsila Center for Urban Sustainability** on the roof of the Central Library in East Jerusalem. Sinsila focuses on women's empowerment, development of employment opportunities and environmental education. In 2022 Sinsila partnered with local institutions to train more than 100 women, providing each woman two beehives as a starting point and leading to the production of 3-4 tons of high-quality biodynamic honey. The organization was awarded the 2022 IIE VICTOR J. GOLDBERG PRIZE FOR PEACE IN THE MIDDLE EAST.

I asked Matan how things were between him and Tareq, given the horrific situation impacting Israel and Gaza. He told me that for a time it had been very difficult between them - that they'd hit bottom - and that they have come out as friends. "We are brothers."

I consider their ongoing partnership, in spite of impossible odds, to be one of the small miracles of this terrible time.

Matan exhorted me to continue to bring international artists to Jerusalem. We both believe Jerusalem is the center of the world. That it is the core of some of the most intractable human problems and yet a place of extreme joy and spirituality (as Vibha so beautifully captured with her sound installation at Muslala.)

He suggested we reframe (possibly rename) the program to be about **Re-Dreaming Jerusalem**. And he insisted that in this fragile time, artists can bring the imagination and skills to start a new way of connecting across great divides.

I had put the JIF on the back burner when the war broke out. People in East and West Jerusalem seemed to me not in a mindset to do anything but deal with the day-to-day of war and grief. Matan inspired me to think that more than anytime, NOW is the hour to figure out how (when this war is over, please god, very soon) to bring artists to Jerusalem to help heal and rebuild relationships. JIF artists create within communities and their art crosses borders.

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If you believe in the power of artists – how their voices are essential to our ability to reflect and heal,

[Please help us build the next Jerusalem residency.](#)

In this dark time, we have to look towards the future and the slivers of light.

I am praying for the lives of the hostages and innocent civilians in Gaza and the West Bank and a quick end to this terrible war.

Wishing you and yours health and safety in the New Year.

- Elise



Vibha's installation on Muslala's rooftop, featuring the voices of Muslims, Jews and Christians singing from their sacred texts about humans and nature.

Here's some reading/listening I've found helpful over the last few weeks:

<https://www.nif.org/stories/human-rights-democracy/building-a-shared-future-together/>

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<https://forward.com/culture/573654/intifada-arabic-israeli-hamas-war-meaning-linguistics>

<https://forward.com/opinion/484874/activists-are-calling-globalize-intifada-demand-for-death-not-peace>

Roger Cohen on how the use of "colonizer" has changed over time:

<https://www.nytimes.com/2023/12/10/world/europe/colonialist-word-gaza-ukraine.html>

The ever inspiring words of Rabbi Amichai Lau-Lavie:

<https://www.npr.org/2023/12/14/1219428292/>

A possible way forward: [A LAND FOR ALL](#)

I want to support International Artists in Jerusalem



Fellows visiting Sinsila in March 2022. Tareq and Matan in the center.

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